

Senator Marshall Joins Bipartisan Call for DOJ Investigation into Fire Department Market Consolidation

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U.S. Senator Roger Marshall (R-Kansas) joined a bipartisan letter led by Senator Amy Klobuchar (D-Minnesota) requesting the Department of Justice investigate consolidation in markets serving fire departments and public safety agencies.

The letter highlights that ESO Solutions, backed by Vista Equity Partners, controls software used by approximately 20,000 of the nation's 30,000 fire departments following multiple acquisitions. Fire departments have reported price increases "from \$795 per year to more than \$5,000," with smaller and volunteer departments particularly affected.

The senators expressed concern that consolidation has reduced competition in critical services including incident reporting and data management software, fire engine manufacturing, emergency radios, and fire retardants and essential equipment.

The letter requests a DOJ investigation into consolidation in the markets for products and services relied on by public safety agencies, to protect communities and first responders from anticompetitive practices, particularly affecting volunteer fire departments lacking alternatives.

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